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to 2.7 million men. District-level data show high deletions in Muslim-majority areas such as Murshidabad, Malda, the Parganas, Uttar Dinajpur and Nadia.

According to Sabar Institute, a Kolkata-based public policy research organisation, in Nandigram, where Muslims constitute 25 per cent of the population, 94.5 per cent of the deleted under-adjudication names are Muslim. The figure in Bhabanipur, which has a Muslim population of 20 per cent, is 40.1 per cent—and this in a key battleground constituency, Mamata's home in South Kolkata. But BJP strongholds have been affected too. In Matua-dominated regions, deletions have impacted many from this pro-BJP Dalit vote base.

These numbers matter because of the narrow winning margins in several constituencies. In 2021, 36 seats were decided by margins less than 5,000 votes. Overall, says Biswanath Chakraborty, political science professor at the Rabindra Bharti University, the number of deleted voters exceeds the 2021 winning margin in 177 constituencies. Of these, the TMC won 119, the BJP 57.

The BJP is hoping a Congress revival in pockets and the residual Left support split the consolidated minority vote that has rallied behind Mamata post the Citizenship Amendment Act and NRC

The Abhishek Factor

Meanwhile, Abhishek Banerjee, Mamata's nephew and TMC's chief strategist, has sought to shift the party's internal culture from one based on loyalty to one driven by performance and data analysis. This time, he has initiated a bottom-up restructuring process. Block-level meetings were conducted across the state, not only to strengthen organisational networks but also to deal with SIR disruptions. To counter anti-incumbency, the party has dropped 74 sitting MLAs and reshuffled 15. This understandably led to dissent, including clashes in Naoda, Murshidabad, but Abhishek has taken it upon himself to manage these fault lines.

The TMC scion is also adopting what his aides describe as "a 3D fight". He conducts 3-4 rallies daily, handles organisational issues while overseeing efforts to assist voters affected by SIR deletions. The TMC is hoping to bolster its 215-seat tally in 2021 with seats where the winning margin was under 15,000 to accomplish what it's calling Mission 250. While Mamata and Abhishek are leading the big rallies, micro meetings are intensifying booth-level outreach. Each assembly constituency has a war room, manned by a 20-member staff. Close to 100,000 shadow agents are tracking booth-level officers and assisting people with electoral roll changes.

The TMC is relying on Mamata's welfare-driven policies to woo the women and youth vote. Her government's Lakshmir Bhandar scheme provides monthly financial assistance of Rs 1,500 per month to women in the general category, and Rs 1,700 for those in the reserved categories. The scheme has reached 2.2 million beneficiaries, with an annual allocation of Rs 267 lakh crore and a total expenditure of Rs 740 lakh crore. A similar scheme for the state's youth, Yuva Sathi, offers Rs 1,500 per month to unemployed youth aged 21-40 for up to five years or until they secure employment. Nearly 10 million applications have been received, and disbursements have begun.

The BJP has now promised to raise these payouts to Rs 3,000 a month, prompting the TMC to challenge the party to fulfil that promise in Delhi first. "The prime minister himself promised before the Delhi assembly election that the BJP government will give Rs 2,500 to every woman of Delhi," Abhishek said at a press conference. "One year has gone by, not a single woman of Delhi has got even five paise."

Besides these flagship schemes, the TMC is also promising a doorstep healthcare initiative, based on its 'Duare Sarkar' model. Called 'Duare Chikitsa', it promises annual health camps in every block and town.